gbawriter 11.0

Full controls · Halim Jarrar

Create and edit TXT files on your Game Boy Advance. Save your writing directly to the SD card. Put TXT files in **/gbawriter** at the root of your SD card, or import them from anywhere on the card (Start on Home). Runs on the SuperCard SD, EZ-Flash Omega (also the Definitive Edition; start the ROM from the SD card, not from NOR) or EverDrive GBA.

Hardware-unverified build: emulator and host tests are not proof of safe saving on a physical flashcart. Back up your SD card and use disposable documents first.

Installation

• A GBA-compatible system and **Supercard SD** using the inherited SuperFW-compatible SD driver, or an **EZ-Flash Omega** or **EverDrive GBA**, see above. Other flashcarts and generic emulator save files are not supported storage backends.

• Copy gbawriter.gba to your flashcart and launch it through its usual ROM loader. The source code is published at github.com/Xinon232/gbawriter.

• Documents live in **/gbawriter/** on the SD card (created at start if missing). Settings and your list order live in the folder /gbawriter/GBAWRITER.SYS (visible on a PC; leave it alone, the app never lists it). Older versions made it hidden and system; the app clears both attributes once at start; nothing is written next to your documents except the transient save files described below.

• Home needs the card, so it is read once at start (Checking SD...). Without a card or with an incompatible one, the driver takes a while to give up; Home then says No SD card, and Controls and Credits still work.

• Back up the SD card before testing. Never remove the card or power off while SAVING is displayed.

Home

Key	Action
Up / Down	Move (hold to scroll; a fresh press at either end wraps)
Left / Right	One page
A	New File: the date picker. A file: open it. The open file (▶): back into it. A acts when it is released.
Hold A + Up / Down	Move the selected file one row (Secret Settings > Reorder list, On by default). New File always stays first.
B	Back to the open file (B: Resume active file)
Start	Import
Select	Menu
L+R (together)	Sleep: the screen goes off and the GBA uses almost no power. **Start held 1 s** wakes it: Home is back as it was, with the open file (▶) and its unsaved text. A shorter Start press leaves it asleep.

Sleep (L+R on Home). Press L and R together on Home: the screen goes off and the GBA stops (BIOS Stop mode, very little power) until you hold **Start** for 1 second. A shorter press (or a Start that bounces up during that second) leaves it asleep: the screen stays off and the GBA stops again at once. Held 1 s, the screen comes back while Start is still down, on Home exactly as it was; the open file (▶)

keeps its unsaved text in memory, so save it afterwards as usual. The Start press that wakes the GBA does nothing else, also when you let go of it (it does not open Import), and every button is ignored until all of them have been released for a moment. L+R work only on Home: in the editor L and R still type, and holding L+R while the app starts still selects the SuperCard driver without putting the GBA to sleep. Sleep is not switching off: with the batteries flat the unsaved text is lost.

At start the cursor is always on **New File**. The first time (no saved order), files are listed as before: diary dates newest first, then other names A to Z (upper/lower case ignored). After you move a file, that order is saved; files the order does not know yet (new, imported or copied on a PC) appear at the top, newest first. Rename keeps a file's place. Up to **1,000 files** are listed.

New File

The date picker proposes the day after the newest diary file in the chosen file name format (or after the last date you chose; at first **10 July 2026**). This is an editable preset, not a real-time clock. Up/Down choose the field, Left/Right change it, A creates, B goes back to Home. The fields follow the format (Month first for MM.DD.YYYY, Year first for YYYY-MM-DD); the file name is shown below. Invalid day combinations are clamped; years 1–9999.

Select > File names	Example
DDMMYYYY (default, as before V4.0)	01102026.txt
DD.MM.YYYY	01.10.2026.txt
MMDDYYYY	10012026.txt
MM.DD.YYYY	10.01.2026.txt
YYYY-MM-DD	2026-10-01.txt (also sorts by date on a PC)

The format only names new files; the list always shows the real names. DDMMYYYY and MMDDYYYY names cannot be told apart, so the proposal only counts files in the chosen format. **New File never overwrites an existing name**, including case-only .TXT differences: a collision shows FILE ALREADY EXISTS and returns to the date picker.

Leaving the editor and the open file

• **Start+A** saves (unchanged). **Start+B** goes to Home **without saving**; nothing is lost: the text stays in memory and the file is the open file: ▶ on its row and B: Resume active file at the bottom. B (or A on that row) returns to the text with the caret, view and Shift/Caps as they were.

• Opening another file or New File while the open file has unsaved changes asks **Unsaved changes: Save / Discard / Cancel** (B = Cancel). Save writes the file first and stops on a save error; Discard drops the changes when the other file opens.

• **There is no autosave: switching off loses text that is not saved.**

Import (Start on Home)

Import to /gbawriter starts at the SD-card root and lists folders (folder icon) and then TXT files, each A to Z. Hidden and system entries, GBAWRITER.SYS and /gbawriter itself are not shown (and cannot be opened). A opens a folder, B goes up, B at the root returns to Home. A on a TXT file asks Import into /gbawriter? (No first); Yes copies it with a percent display. When the name is used (also in other upper/lower case) the app offers Yes, as Name (2).txt (numbers 2 to 99). A failed copy leaves no partial file. Home then shows the new file at the top, selected, with Imported. The original stays where it is.

Select menu

On a file the title is its name and the first rows act on it:

• **Rename:** the name without .txt in a field, typed with the gbawriter letters below; Start+A saves, Start+B cancels; .txt is added. Not allowed: an empty name, / \ : * ? " < > |, a name ending in a space or a dot, a name already used (also in other upper/lower case). Changing only upper/lower case works.

• **Delete** (only when Secret Settings > Delete files is On): the row turns into Sure?; A again deletes the TXT file, B or moving cancels.

• The **open file** (▶) cannot be renamed or deleted: This file is open. Open another file first. Files with recovery copies (.gwt, .gwb, .gwi) are refused with RECOVERY: CHECK SD ON PC.

Then for every row: **File names: …** (A switches the format; the row always shows the example date 13 July 2026, so day and month are easy to tell apart: 13072026, 13.07.2026, 07132026, 07.13.2026, 2026-07-13), **Helper line: On / Off** (V4.1: whether the helper line at the bottom of the editor is shown when a file opens; saved, default On; Start+Select still toggles it while writing; a line under this row separates the settings from the instructions below), the Controls topics (Files and menus, Letters, L layer, Spaces and case, Symbols, Accents, Caret and saving) and **Credits**. Pages: Left/Right turn, B returns to the menu.

Credits — page 1, About: gbawriter 11.0, (c) 2026 Halim Jarrar, halimj.itch.io, gba@halim-jarrar.de, GPL-3.0-or-later, No warranty, Source: github.com/Xinon232/gbawriter; then License, Text and fonts, SD card drivers, Files and engine, and **Secret Settings** (press A):

• Reorder list (A+DPAD): On (default On)

• Delete files: Off (default Off)

• Delete configuration: Sure?, A again removes GBAWRITER.SYS (settings and order back to their defaults; documents are never touched).

Typing

The editor and all typing controls are unchanged from V3.0, except that Start+B no longer saves (see above). The full-controls PDF has every control; regenerate it with python3 tools/build_controls_pdf.py (ReportLab and DejaVu Sans).

Hold a direction, then press **B / A / R** to choose its **first / second / third** letter. Lowercase is the default.

Direction	Normal: B / A / R	Hold L: B / A / R
Up	a / b / c	d / e / f
Right	h / i / j	k / l / m
Down	n / o / p	q / r / s
Left	t / u / w	x / y / z

L is held, never toggled. Diagonals are not letter groups.

• Keep Right held and press R twice: the first j becomes **g**.

• Keep Left held and press R twice: the first w becomes **v**.

• Release the group between presses to type literal jj or ww. These transformations depend on the same continuous hold, **not timing**, and never substitute unrelated text.

• **A alone:** space. **B alone:** backspace one UTF-8 codepoint; no effect at the beginning. Hold either button alone to repeat: one immediate edit, first repeat after **24 frames**, then every **5 frames**, exactly matching START navigation. Adding any other button cancels edit repeat; releasing a chord's

modifier does not start it. Release A/B and press it alone again to rearm. Letter/SELECT/save chords remain press-only.

• **START released alone:** newline. Holding it does not insert immediately.

Shift and Caps

From normal case, **release a short isolated R press to arm one-shot Shift**. Hold **R alone continuously for 48 frames** (twice the initial A-repeat delay; about 0.8 seconds at 60 Hz) to enable **Caps while still held**, once per hold. Any other button before the threshold cancels that hold; releasing the companion cannot restart it. Release R and start a fresh solo hold.

With **Shift or Caps already active**, another isolated R press—short or long—**clears the mode on release**. It cannot arm Shift or Caps again during the same hold. Shift applies to the next successfully inserted alphabetic character; digits, spaces and punctuation do not consume it.

With Caps on, one isolated R press/release turns Caps off without arming Shift. R inside a direction group remains the third-letter key and cannot toggle Caps. Shift/Caps applies to the international letters below; ß stays ß, never two letters. Rejected capacity-limited edits do not consume Shift. A failed save preserves Shift/Caps as well as the document.

The bottom status bar reads **filename → active letter group → Shift/Caps**. The filename starts at x=8 (128-pixel slot), the group at x=144 (32-pixel slot), and Shift/Caps at x=184 (48-pixel slot): hold Up to see abc, or ABC with Shift/Caps; all normal and held-L groups follow the same rule. Release the direction to clear it; diagonals and START navigation show no letter group. * marks unsaved changes. Transient messages occupy only the filename slot, leaving capitalization and group visible.

START commands

Hold START, then:

Button	Action
Left / Right	Move caret one UTF-8 codepoint
Up / Down	Move to the closest horizontal position in the adjacent visual row
L / R	Previous / next viewport page, maintaining a valid caret
A	Save the current file
B	Back to Home **without saving**; the text stays open (▶, B: Resume active file)
SELECT	Toggle the helper line (bottom status bar) / full-screen editor

Navigation repeats while held. Releasing START after a recognized command **does not add a newline**, even when saving fails. A save failure opens a clear error message and returns to the editor with text retained after acknowledgment. There is no autosave.

SELECT: one provisional character

Press SELECT alone to insert **. immediately**. Keep SELECT held to change **that same character**; release to keep it. Exception: SELECT after an eligible continuously held letter chord converts the existing letter instead (see International letters). Cycling never appends additional characters.

While SELECT is held	Cycle
Up	. → 1 → 2 → 3 → 4 → 5 → 6 → 7 → 8 → 9 → 0 → 1 …
Down	. → 0 → 9 → 8 → 7 → 6 → 5 → 4 → 3 → 2 → 1 → 0 …

While SELECT is held	Cycle
R, without a direction	. → , → ' → " → : → ! → ? → .
L, without a completed letter chord	Exact reverse common-punctuation cycle
Right	. → (→) → / → ; → @ → # → % → & → _ → + → = → - → .
Left	Exact reverse additional-symbol cycle

A completed letter chord takes priority over intermediate directional/punctuation changes. For example SELECT, then Up, then L, then A changes the same provisional . to 1 and then to é, not three characters. A complete L-layer chord similarly overrides the temporary SELECT+L punctuation step. Unsupported accent families leave the provisional glyph unchanged. **START+SELECT toggles the status bar in the editor only**, in either press order. It cancels only a newly inserted SELECT provisional character, restoring the original caret and dirty state. A converted existing letter stays accented; it is not deleted. The chord never types, saves, or adds a newline. It toggles once per hold and suppresses commands until both START and SELECT are released; other held buttons do not prevent rearming.

International letters

Accents work in either order: hold SELECT, then enter the normal letter combination; or enter a letter and keep its **exact single D-pad direction, L if used, and producing B/A/R button continuously held**, then press SELECT. That same letter changes to its first accented variant, keeping its case, without adding a period or another letter. There is no time limit, but releasing or changing the combination ends eligibility. Other extra buttons disqualify this letter-first gesture; diagonals are not letter groups. A letter with no accent variants stays unchanged in the letter-first order.

Example: hold L+UP and press A to type e; keep L+UP+A held and press SELECT to turn that same e into é. In the other order, hold SELECT, then L+UP and press A to produce é as one character. The held-L groups work in both orders too.

While SELECT and the same group remain held, **release and press the final B/A/R selector again** to cycle in the exact order below. Keep the direction and L layer (if used) held during cycling. Release SELECT to keep the current result. The letter-first result keeps the original letter's lowercase/Shift/Caps case, even after one-shot Shift was consumed.

Family	Lowercase cycle	Uppercase equivalents
A	á ä à â ã å æ	Á Ä À Â Ã Å Æ
C	ç č ć	Ç Č Ć
E	é è ë ê	É È Ë Ê
I	í ï ì î	Í Ï Ì Î
N	ñ ń	Ñ Ń
O	ó ö ô ò õ ø œ	Ó Ö Ô Ò Õ Ø Œ
S	ß š ś	ß Š Ś
U	ü ú ù û	Ü Ú Ù Û
Y	ý ÿ	Ý Ÿ
Z	ž ź ż	Ž Ź Ż

E/S/Y/Z use the held L layer; N/O/U are unmodified groups. Cycles wrap back to the first alternate. All 77 distinct required lowercase/uppercase glyphs are verified against the real font packs and renderer, including even/odd pixel addressing. Home **SELECT** opens the menu with the Controls topics; Left/Right changes page; B returns. Help strings are checked for glyph coverage and screen width.

Storage

Files up to 2 GiB open (a larger one shows FILE TOO LARGE and is left as it is): they stay on the SD card and only changes use RAM. Up to 64 KiB of typed text can be unsaved at once; when the bar shows BUFFER FULL - SAVE, save to continue (the text is kept). Saving a large file takes longer. Saves change only the opened TXT file. Settings and the list order are kept in the folder /gbawriter/GBAWRITER.SYS (visible on a PC; the app does not list it). Temporary .gwt, .gwb and .gwi recovery files may remain after interrupted or failed saves. Do not delete them on the original card: back up the card and consult the README recovery instructions. There is no undo/redo or autosave: switching off loses text that is not saved.

About / license

gbawriter 11.0 · Copyright (c) 2026 Halim Jarrar · halimj.itch.io · gba@halim-jarrar.de

gbawriter is free software: you can redistribute it and/or modify it under the terms of the GNU General Public License as published by the Free Software Foundation, either version 3 of the License, or (at your option) any later version (GPL-3.0-or-later).

No warranty: gbawriter is distributed in the hope that it will be useful, but WITHOUT ANY WARRANTY; without even the implied warranty of MERCHANTABILITY or FITNESS FOR A PARTICULAR PURPOSE. See the GNU General Public License for more details.

Source code: github.com/Xinon232/gbawriter

Credits: text renderer, UTF-8 helpers and font packs: SuperFW by David Guillen Fandos (GPL-3.0-or-later). Fonts: UNSCII by Viznut and GNU Unifont, also its Hangul blocks (GPL-2.0-or-later with the font embedding exception). UI font: gbamp3 by Halim Jarrar (GPL-3.0-or-later). SuperCard SD driver: SuperFW by David Guillen Fandos (GPL-3.0-or-later). EverDrive GBA SD code: edio-gba by krikzz (MIT). EZ-Flash Omega driver: Halim Jarrar, after the Omega kernel (Apache-2.0). SD card code: gbaSD by Halim Jarrar (GPL-3.0-or-later). File system: FatFs by ChaN (FatFs license, BSD style). Engine: Butano by Gustavo Valiente (zlib). Built with devkitPro / devkitARM. See LICENSE and NOTICES.md in the source.